

on one's own. There are, after all, worse things out there than rivals who claim to have the ear of Heaven.

## The Breath of Life

The Hsien are unlike the fae, the strange visitors from the West who call them cousin for reasons the Shinma do not entirely understand. They are not forgotten creatures of dreamstuff, but the functionaries of a grand celestial order, small gods of pure Chi who conduct and guide its flow through the world in order to answer the prayers of mortals and beasts alike. The Chi that makes up their form thus empowers them, and through attunement to the natural Chi of the world, they may forge great, elementally-empowered miracles through their wondrous art of alchemy, Wu Tan.

## Chi

All things consist of Chi, the duality of Yin and Yang, dark and light, stillness and energy, that complement without opposing. So too are the Shinma, who exist as pure Chi in their natural form but hide within mortal bodies. Their nature makes them tempting targets for a multitude of creatures who dine on Chi, and if such a creature does devour the Hsien, she is destroyed, never to reincarnate again through the kun shou.

Hsien may sacrifice a point of their Chi to generate a point of Yugen, but doing so causes one level of aggravated damage per point sacrificed. The point of Chi lost will not regenerate until the wound heals.

## Yugen

A different form of energy altogether, ineffable and brilliant, that forms from the prayers of mortals. Individual prayers are too small to grant usable quantities, but celebrations, festivals, and religious observances will generate copious quantities, which the Shinma take for themselves. Cut off as they are from the boundless Chi of Heaven, it is their sole source of sustenance and power.

## Creating a Hsien Character

Creating one of the Shinma is not quite the same as creating one of the Kithain. Those Traits that remain unchanged will pass largely unmentioned — please refer to changeling character creation (p. 140) for details.

## Hsien Courts

In the power vacuum that followed the Shinma expulsion from Heaven, it is no surprise that many pretenders have arisen. Some claim to carry on the will of the August Personage of Jade, while others flaunt their worldly desires and motivations. While some Hsien serve the same court in life after life, the truth is that each reincarnation subtly changes her — a long history of serving one court need not predispose her next incarnation to continue the tradition.

Most of the following courts are considered mainstream, or at the very least not fundamentally corrupted (though some courts might disagree even with that assessment!).

### ☉ Li Shen — The Traditionalists

The Li Shen Court is divided into five bureaucracies, one for each of the five elements, and strongly endorses and follows Confucian ethics and values. Their emphasis is not on enlightenment per se, but order, from which they hold that enlightenment (and therefore an end to their exile) will naturally occur.

### ☉ Xian Mo — The Quiet Ones

The Xian Mo are a mystical society that follows the Tao Te Hsien, seeking out enlightenment in the hope that they may, one day, be able to reverse the Ages and their exile in the Middle Kingdom. They have little formal organization but a vast depth of knowledge, assuming you can find the elder who possesses it and convince her to share it.

### ☉ Yü — The Classicists

The Yü style themselves after ancient kings, dividing the Middle Kingdom between them and ruling over 10 “provinces,” seeking to control dragon nests and mortal power structures alike. Some are little better than crime lords, but power is power, and it is unwise to anger the Yü, who war amongst themselves almost as much as they make war against outsiders.

### ☉ Xian Mun — The Worldly

Less a court than a way of life, the Immortal Society consists of those Shinma who turn their backs on their origins and seek only to live this one life to the fullest, often mimicking mortal organizations and seeking nothing more than to relieve themselves of obligations and onerous duties. Virtually every other court considers the Xian Mun dissolute wastes of human bodies, but their connections to mortal society and resources eclipse those of any other court, even the Yü.

### ☉ Wu Hsien — The Peasants

A catchall for those Hsien who, like so many mortals, still live a country lifestyle, often in the village of their birth (or rebirth, as the case may be). While Shinma are not so common that every village sports a large population, a villager Hsien is likely to know everything about her village, and to have close ties with any neighboring Hsien for the sake of safety if nothing else.

### ☉ Tu Shen — The Ambassadors of Heaven

While most see the Gods of Harmony as little more than sybarites who put even the Xian Mun to shame, there is a method to the Tu Shen's madness — they hope to create an Age of Joy, and so lead by example, doing everything in their power to make life the very best that it can be. Unlike the Xian Mun, the Tu Shen's passion and celebration are steeped in faith, and they do their utmost to create joy wherever they go, even if it's just a family dinner or a night drinking with friends.

### ☉ Shu Shen — The Profane Gods

Disdaining the idea of balance — nay, despising it! — these Hsien pursue the most extreme of behaviors, few